Partner commission schedule and referral tracking check

Checklist items 5.2 and 5.4 · 6 November 2026 · for the Partner Agreement V2, still waiting on 5.1 and 5.3

The short version

- **Recommended schedule: 20% of the net payment for a user's first 12 months as a payer, with 25% for named partners and a hard ceiling of 30%.** 30% leaves at least 25% margin on every plan even when a customer uses Ask KiqStat to its daily cap every day; 35% does not. No 35% promise should go in the agreement.
- **The partner system works up to the point of money, but has never been used with money.** There are 3 partners and 3 referred signups, none of whom has paid, so there are 0 commissions. Everything below is tested in code and in a rolled-back run on the live database, not seen with a real payment.
- **One real gap found and fixed:** a Paystack refund marked the payment refunded but left the partner's commission standing, so a partner could be paid on money that went back. It now cancels a held commission, or leaves a clawback on the next payout if it was already paid (`src/app/api/billing/webhook/route.ts`).

5.2 The schedule

How the deal works today (from the code)

Rule	Today
Basis	Rate × the net payment (amount paid minus the processor's fee)
Default rate	20% (`DEFAULT_RATE_BPS`)
Highest rate the admin can set	50% (`MAX_RATE_BPS`)
Who earns	Payments by a user the partner brought, for the user's first 12 months as a payer
Attribution	The partner's link `?ref=<code>` sets a cookie; signing up within 90 days credits the partner
Hold	14 days (the refund window), then payable
Minimum payout	₦10,000 per currency; smaller balances roll over
Live partners	kingbra 20%, squid 25%, scaper 20% (suspended)

What each payment earns a partner at 20% (₦)

Plan	Price	Paystack fee	Net	Partner earns
₦500 VIP day pass	500	8	492	98

Plan	Price	Paystack fee	Net	Partner earns
Pro monthly	5,000	175	4,825	965
Pro quarterly	13,500	303	13,197	2,639
Pro yearly	48,000	820	47,180	9,436
VIP monthly	12,000	280	11,720	2,344
VIP quarterly	32,400	586	31,814	6,363
VIP yearly	115,200	1,828	113,372	22,674

So a partner who brings one Pro customer who pays once earns ₦965; one who stays on VIP monthly for the full 12 months earns about ₦28,000. To reach the ₦10,000 minimum payout, a partner needs roughly eleven Pro monthly sales.

What the model allows (from the plan economics report, ~~₦~~1,550 to the dollar)

Case	Largest commission that still leaves a 25% margin
Typical Ask KiqStat use	72% to 73%, every plan
Ask KiqStat at the daily cap every day (worst case)	31% (Week pass) to 37% (day and weekend passes); Pro monthly 36%, Pro quarterly 32%, VIP 35%

Margin here is before fixed costs. Fixed costs of about ₦95,000 to ₦108,000 a month (estimate, invoices pending) need about 20 to 23 Pro customers with no partner, 25 to 29 at 20%, and 31 to 35 at 35%. A high rate therefore costs more in volume needed than in per-customer margin.

Recommendation

Item	Proposal	Why
Standard rate	20% of net, months 1 to 12	Safe on every plan in the worst case with room to spare (35% to 42% margin at 20% in the worst case, 75% to 77% typical)
Higher rate	25% for named partners, agreed in writing	The model clears it at any plausible rate
Hard ceiling	30%, set in the code and the agreement	The model's limit in the worst case is 31% to 37% at ₦1,550, so 30% is the last round figure inside it; at ₦1,700 the room is thinner, so re-run `scripts/plan-economics.ts` before raising anyone above 25%
Not offered	35%	Misses 25% in the worst case on most plans (24.6% to 24.7% on VIP, lower on Pro

Item	Proposal	Why
		quarterly and yearly)
Basis	Net of the processor's fee, as now	A partner is paid on cash that arrives
Window	12 months from the user's first payment	As now
Hold	14 days, with clawback of paid commission if refunded	As now, now enforced automatically for Paystack refunds
Minimum payout	₦10,000, balance rolls over	As now

Two changes needed in the code if the founder agrees: lower the ceiling from 50% to 30% (`MAX_RATE_BPS` in `src/lib/partners.ts`), and leave the 20% default. Rates above 20% for a partner remain an explicit admin decision.

Decisions left to the founder and the legal adviser (5.1, 5.3): the questionnaire answers, tax on commission, partner status (independent, not an employee), the cap on what a partner may say about returns, and termination rights.

5.4 Referral tracking check

The chain, link by link

Step	Where	Checked how	Result
Link `?ref=<code>` sets a 90-day cookie	partner-ref, proxy	code read; unit tests	Works as designed
Signup credits the partner (new account, created after the click, partner active, not self)	`attributeSignup`	code read; tests	Works as designed
Late credit (Google sign-in that skipped the callback, or admin credit) pays past payments	`creditPastPayments`	code read	Works as designed; payment reference is unique so it cannot double pay
A payment earns a commission	`recordCommission`, called from the Paystack webhook, pay-once, passes and offers, the daily subscription check, and Flutterwave	code read; 12-month window and fee tests	Every path that grants access also credits; the payment recovery path uses the same grant functions
Commission held 14 days, payable after	`partner_commissions.payable_at`	schema read	Works as designed

Step	Where	Checked how	Result
Payout	`partner_pay_out`	schema read; payout tests	Works; refuses below the minimum
Refund or chargeback reverses	`partner_reverse_commission`	**run on the live database inside a rolled-back transaction**	Held commission becomes cancelled; a paid one gets a negative clawback row of the same amount for the next payout; reversing twice returns "already"
Paystack refund triggers the reversal	webhook `refund.processed`	code read	**Was missing; fixed** (see below)

Live data

Measure	Value
Partners	3 (2 active, 1 suspended)
Referred signups	3 (one per partner)
Referred accounts that have paid	0
Commissions or clawbacks	0

The test run left no rows behind. This means nothing here proves the chain with a real payment: the first one will.

The gap and the fix

Before: a refund from the Paystack dashboard set the payment to refunded and ended a pass, but the partner's commission stayed pending or paid unless the admin reversed it by hand on the partner page.

After: the same webhook now finds the commission for that payment and calls the same reversal function the admin button calls. A partial refund reverses the whole commission, which is the cautious side; the admin can see the reason ("refunded (Paystack)"). A refund made outside Paystack (for example a Flutterwave refund) still needs the admin reversal, because that provider's refund event is not handled.

To do before partners are told it is live

1. Send one real test: refer a test account through a partner link, make a ₦500 payment, and watch the commission appear on the partner page. Then refund it from Paystack and confirm the commission cancels.
2. Decide the ceiling (30%) and update the agreement.
3. Handle Flutterwave refunds the same way, if Flutterwave is used for partners' customers.

Method and limits

- Rates and margins come from `docs/reports/plan-economics-2026-11.md` and the live code; nothing here is a legal opinion.
- Partner earnings use the Paystack fee estimate (1.5% + ₦100 from ₦2,500, cap ₦2,000); the real fee on a payment can differ slightly.
- The refund fix is covered by typecheck and by the existing reversal function; there is no automated test of the webhook route itself.